

Hearts

Card Deck · 3 to 5 players, every player for themselves · about 30 minutes

House rules written for The Game Room. These are the common rules; plenty of tables play their own variations, so agree on any before you start.

How to play

With 4 players, deal all 52 cards, 13 each. Before each hand, pass three cards: to the left, then to the right, then across, then no pass, and repeat.

The player holding the 2 of clubs leads it. Follow suit if you can; otherwise play anything. There is no trump: the highest card of the suit led wins the trick. Hearts cannot be led until a heart has been played on another suit, unless you hold nothing but hearts. By common house rule, no hearts or queen of spades may be played on the first trick.

Scoring: each heart you take is 1 point and the queen of spades is 13. Take every heart and the queen of spades (shooting the moon) and you score 0 while everyone else scores 26. When someone reaches 100, the lowest score wins.

With 3 or 5 players

With 3 players, take the 2 of diamonds out of the deck and deal 17 cards each. With 5 players, take out the 2 of diamonds and the 2 of clubs and deal 10 each; the 3 of clubs leads the first trick. With either, there is no across: pass three cards left, then right, then no pass, and repeat. Scoring is the same.